I was almost waiting for the nerves to start jangling but the lads were just as confident over breakfast as they had been over dinner the night before and, even an hour before kick-off in the dressing room, everyone seemed calm and relaxed. We went out to warm up and everything seemed right. Everything, that is, apart from my injury. I still wasn't sure. I knew I wanted to play but I knew I had to do what was best for the team. Those few minutes running and stretching, though, made all the difference and I came back in convinced I could make it. When the time came, in the minute or two before the bell rang to tell us to go out for the game, Sven sat everybody down. What he had to say was pretty simple but tapped into everybody's mood:

'Go out, enjoy yourselves. Be confident: they're a good team but we're a better team. Play well. And three points.'

Sven always finishes with that: 'And three points'. I stood up and led the team out into the tunnel. The doctors had talked me into putting on a pair of lycra cycling shorts just to keep me warm and to give a bit of extra support. Even standing in the tunnel, I knew I'd made a mistake agreeing to wear them. I've always been the kind of player who needs to be comfortable with what I've got on: not just my boots but the rest of my uniform too. If I've got blisters, I can't wear an extra pair of socks or a plaster on a sore toe. Maybe it's all in the mind, but I know it makes a real difference to me. Waiting to go out for this huge game, I felt like I'd been strapped into these things. It wasn't really the right moment, though, to be changing my mind.

We kicked off and, in no time, we were a goal down. I'd not even had long enough to stop worrying about not feeling right. The injury wasn't bothering me but the cycling shorts were. Surely, if the groin was going to go, then it was going to go anyway. I jogged across to the touchline and peeled them off. One of the papers got a photo of me stripping off by the dugout and ran it the next day with a jokey headline about the England captain changing the game by changing his shorts. Getting rid of them did change things for me: I felt better straight away, freer and able to run more easily. I didn't give the injury another thought for the rest of the game.

Usually, going a goal behind would have been the worst possible thing that could happen. Give Germany a head start and you expect them to bunker in the defensive end and look to counterattack. That's exactly what had happened at Wembley, wasn't it? Here at the Olympic Stadium, it didn't bother us at all. Nobody panicked, nobody started having second thoughts. It felt like it had at the Stadio Delle Alpi with United, the night we were 2–0 down to Juventus but came back to win and reach the European Cup Final.